Rahul ji greeted me with a handshake and a smile, saying, ‘I’ll talk to you in a couple of minutes. In the meantime, make your way from the left to the right, and be careful not to bump into me.’ I followed his suggestion and walked to the other side, where the former deputy chief minister of Rajasthan, Sachin Pilot, was also walking. Sachin ji looked at me and said, ‘With all this roaming, your hair has also turned grey.’ I remarked that his hair had also turned grey! After this I talked to him for some more time, while Rahul ji spoke to a local leader. Once he was free, he walked towards me, and our conversation started. I once again introduced myself to Rahul ji. When I told him that I had become a volunteer for the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) when I was a teenager, he had a look of both surprise and curiosity on his face. He inquired, ‘What was your experience in the RSS like?’

I told him that when I was thirteen years old and studying in seventh class, Banshi Lal, a geography teacher, started an RSS shakha in a public place in our village where we used to play and exercise. Soon we started raising slogans in the shakha and learnt to sing songs. Our games were such that they aroused the spirit of extreme nationalism, and we were taught things about the minority community that could only be called illogical. We learnt that Gandhi’s non-violence was cowardice and that Nehru and Gandhi had together divided the country, that Muslims were invaders and had destroyed our temples.[1]

I was part of the RSS for five years, and rose from volunteer to head teacher, caretaker and district office head. I went to participate in the kar seva to demolish the Babri Masjid in 1990. I did not reach Ayodhya, as I was arrested at the Tundla station after Mathura. I was kept in Agra’s Multipurpose Stadium Jail (a stadium temporarily converted into a jail) for ten days. After returning from there I was active in the RSS, but in 1991 I took part in the demonstration under the ‘Hand over the temple or leave the throne’ movement, where a bullet was fired and two people were killed after being shot by the police. While they had nothing to do with this protest or the Ram Mandir movement but were Hindus, both were declared martyrs and a funeral procession was taken out with their ashes in urns. This